Autistic Representation and Advocacy Goals: A Text Analysis

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Introduction

While autism awareness has been in the public consciousness for a considerable time, with various events, fundraisers, and education campaigns put forward each April by neurotypical-led organizations, in recent years autistic self-advocates have gained a greater space on the public stage. The broader neurodiversity movement has worked toward greater inclusion, acceptance, and accommodation of people with various neurotypes.

With the publication of memoirs, articles, and other nonfiction media by autistic people and increased representation of autistic characters written and/or portrayed by autistic writers and actors, autistic voices have drawn more attention than ever before. This attention and the increased interconnectedness of the digital world has led to many benefits for autistic people worldwide, not least of which being the ability to communicate with one another, organize, and share common experiences on social media, often using hashtags like #actuallyautistic. Yet these boons have also come with increased scrutiny of autistic lives, controversy both within the autistic community and with the non-autistic community, and a general polarizing of public opinion about autism and individual autistic people.

Representation in mainstream media has an impact that resonates far beyond the screen or the page. Portrayals in media can serve as a source of education for the general public about autism and other conditions (Aspler et al. 2022). The question then becomes what are the public learning from such portrayals?

This project seeks to answer the following questions: Do current conversations around media produced by and representing autistic people center around the aims of autistic advocates? Are sentiments more positive in conversations centering actually autistic media? Have positive attitudes toward autism and autistic people increased in recent years?

Background

Various disciplines have explored the question of autistic representation and its impact on the broader culture. There exist widely varying representations of autistics in a variety of mainstream media, with Mittman et al. (2024) finding greater instances of stigmatization of autism and autistics in newspapers compared to other forms of media. The authors also call for additional research focusing on newer forms of media, particularly social media.

Autism has long been associated with various negative stereotypes, but the infantilization of autistic people is one area of frustration for the autistic community. Akhtar et al. (2022) found an increase in the representation of autistic adults in media as compared to ten years prior, yet autistic children were still overrepresented in comparison to adults.

Autistic people's own reception of representation in media is mixed. Jones (2024) found that while autistic study participants identified several positive representations of autistic people, they mostly disapproved of the representations of autistic characters in mainstream media. This study also called out the lack of positive representation, particularly representation in novels, which may be due to the study's participants being adults, while the majority of autistic representation in fiction is aimed at children and teens.

Methodology

This project analyzes news articles and social media postings from 2020 to the present day, discussing works by autistic authors, actors, and creators, as well as the broader conversation about autism. Using python libraries and techniques, this project performs sentiment analysis and examines collocation, concordances, and word frequency to ascertain whether various articles and discussions center around aims of autistic advocacy. This study will focus on aims of advocacy identified by autistic-led advocacy organizations, like the Autistic Self Advocacy Network.

This project focuses on media produced in English and thus its impact on the English-speaking world.

Impact

This analysis can help shape the direction autistic media creators take in future projects and the activities autistic advocates choose to pursue.

Knowing the general direction of conversations about autism from within and without the autistic community can help autistic advocates and creators choose areas of focus to better achieve specific aims and increase inclusion for the community as a whole.

Text analysis can also reveal tension between various groups claiming to advocate for the autistic community, as aims of autistic-led and non-autistic-led groups can differ strikingly. Autism Speaks, the most widely known autism advocacy group, is neurotypical-led and has been widely criticized by many advocates in the autistic community (Luterman 2020). Additionally, like any community, the autistic community is not a monolith, and there are controversies, differing aims, and tensions within the community itself, which may be further illuminated by this analysis. Intersectional identities also play a role in the needs and aims of autistic people, and text analysis can reveal these differences.

It has long been common wisdom that positive representation of marginalized groups in media increases general acceptance and inclusion, but actual analysis is needed to determine whether this is truly the case. Furthermore, positive attitudes do not go far enough to address the needs of the autistic community. Autistic advocates want actual inclusion and accommodation, and this analysis can shed light on whether representation is getting the autistic community closer to these important goals.

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